

After Redis and MongoDB, now Confluent sets restrictions on software usage

Confluent, a startup founded by the creators of Kafka, has joined the league of major open source tech companies who have set restrictions on usage of their software.

Confluent has announced that it is changing the licence for some of the components of the Confluent Platform from Apache 2.0 to the Confluent Community License. The move is apparently to prevent large clouds from using its software for their own profits.

This new licence is very much like Apache 2.0 in the sense that it allows users to freely download, modify, and redistribute the code, but it doesn't allow users to provide the software as a SaaS offering.

"What this means is that, for example, you can use KSQL however you see fit as an ingredient in your own products or services, whether those products are delivered as software or as SaaS, but you cannot create a KSQL-as-a-service offering," Confluent co-founder and CEO Jay Kreps explains in a blog post.

However, it does not change anything about Apache Kafka, the widely used open source data streaming project. It still remains under the Apache 2.0 licence. The move came after Amazon Web Services unveiled a managed version of Kafka at re:Invent 2018.

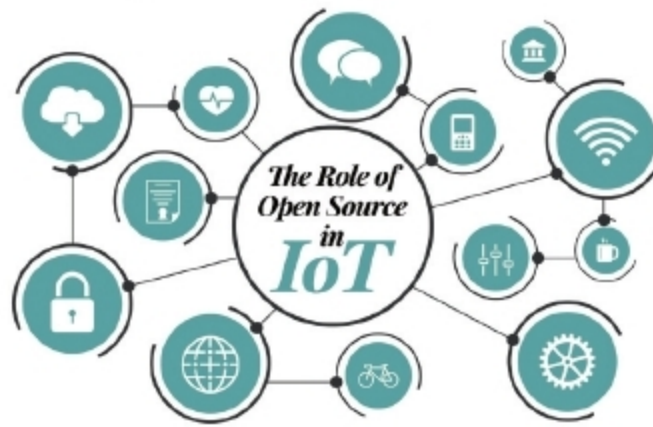
Jay Kreps calls Confluent's move "a necessary step," and says that it will let the company continue to invest heavily in code that it distributes for free, while sustaining a healthy business that funds this investment.

Kreps explains, "In a world in which data systems are delivered as on-premises software, we as an industry have figured out how to build sustainable companies that can drive this kind of virtuous cycle. It isn't easy, but starting a company never is. In that model, we've found that permissive open source licensing such as Apache 2.0 can be the major component of a thriving software offering that sustains a healthy business.

Over the last six months, three open source tech companies, Confluent being the latest, have set restrictions on the usage of their software. Earlier, Redis and MongoDB made similar moves.

With the Ockam SDK, developers can build Ockam functionality into their applications or embedded software. It allows developers to add identity, trust and interoperability to IoT devices.

The developers who integrate the Ockam SDK to the firmware in their connected devices become clients to the Ockam Network. They then receive a unique decentralised ID (did:ockam), following which they can share data as a verified claim with another device, and can also verify data that they receive from other IoT devices that are registered with the network.



IoT network architecture or complex cryptographic key identity management to use Ockam. They can interact with the network with simple functions incorporated in their code, and only pay for what they consume.

Highlighting that Ockam is interoperable and built for multi-party IoT networks, the company claims it is the new backbone for the next generation of high performance IoT ecosystems. The company also refers to itself as the Twilio of IoT.

Ockam is tuned to meet the complex needs of an IoT system. It is built upon the proven developer-first model of Heroku/Twilio/Stripe, which completely removes the technical complexity of the cloud, telecommunications and payments. Developers only need to know a couple of Ockam functions from the SDK to tune their IoT devices and applications and pay on a per use basis.

"We eliminate the blind spots for developers so that they don't need to focus on difficult architecture decisions or go to the expense required to build and maintain their own infrastructure," the company states.

Microsoft Engineering is a technical partner of Ockam. With Azure confidential computing, the Ockam network is able to deliver high performance.

For now, access to the Ockam network is free to developers. This is likely to change when the network becomes generally available. The anticipated GA (general availability) date is later in 2019.

Open source startup Tidelift raises US\$ 25 million in Series B funding

Tidelift, a startup founded by a group of former Red Hat employees, has announced that it has raised US\$ 25 million in new funding to accelerate the adoption of its new business model for open source. This model pays creators to maintain and secure thousands of projects vital to professional software development teams.

General Catalyst, the Foundry Group, and former Red Hat chairman and CEO, Matthew Szulik, joined together to lead the Series B funding round. Last year, the company had raised US\$ 15 million in the Series A round.

The company plans to use the new funding to further expand its coverage of popular open source packages and include more open source creators.

Tidelift subscription gives organisations the security, licensing and maintenance guarantees they need for the open source software components their applications depend on. Through this subscription, open source maintainers also get financial support to continue their projects.